us that it would be best if we left, because the crowds were getting unmanageable. It was honestly very surprising to see the kind of enthusiasm and fervour the Yatra had sparked in Delhi, and that, too, on one of the coldest and foggiest days of the year. The warmth of the people warmed every heart.

What was most striking during the walk was the reception Rahul Gandhi got all along the route, with women showering him with rose petals throughout. Surely, I thought to myself, the Congress could not lose an election in these constituencies next time. I apologized to Rahul for slowing him down, but he was grace personified and said he needed to slow down. Watching him walk, one noticed that he never flinched, appeared weary or despaired. On the contrary, Rahul Gandhi appeared to be burning with idealism. I could not help but feel a soft natural bounding myself.

I genuinely felt it had been a journey well worth walking. When we settled down for a warm cup of tea at home, I got a call from Farooq Abdullah, who had walked with Rahul Gandhi a little while from where we had left. Farooq said, ‘I have been watching photographs of your walk.’ And then added after a pregnant pause, ‘I have never felt as emotional as when the young man hugged me. It was a very special moment.’

I believed that was to be the end of my rendezvous with the young man, but lo and behold, just a few days later, I got another call. ‘Rahul Gandhi would like you to have coffee with him at 10 a.m. on the 13th.’ That early in the morning (especially in the cold Delhi mornings) was never easy, but it was an invitation I felt I could not refuse, partly because not many people invite an old man any more.

It was another enchanting morning. Having been in the business of observing people minutely, this occasion gave me an opportunity to watch the young man closely. He received me in the lawns of his house with a hot mug of coffee. My first question to Rahul Gandhi was: ‘How would you like me to address you?’ It reminded me of Sunil Gavaskar’s question to Bishan Singh Bedi about how to address Tiger Pataudi the first time he played under him. Bedi’s answer to Gavaskar had been to just call him